

The Rise and Fall of Converbs in Classical Armenian

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Converbs from a cross-linguistic perspective
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Key Questions

1. How and why does Classical Armenian develop a cvb category?
2. How does the CArm. cvb operate synchronically?
3. How and why does it develop diachronically?

Outline

Background

Adjective, Perfect, or Converb?

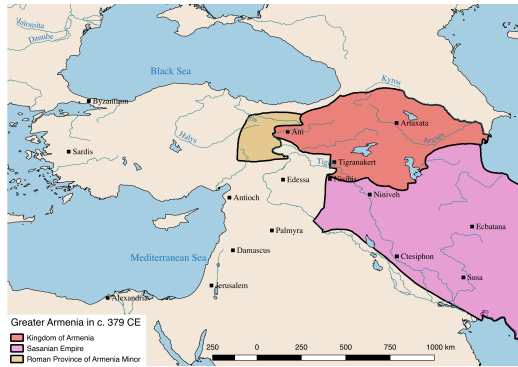
Synchronic use of the Converb

Rise and Fall of the Converb

Final thoughts

Background: Armenian

- ▶ Indo-European language, separate branch (CLACKSON 1994; HÜBSCHMANN 1875; MARTIROSYAN 2013)
- ▶ spoken in Armenian Highlands and surrounding area (modern Armenia, Iran, Turkey, Georgia, Azerbaijan)
- ▶ Classical form (5th–9th c.) heavily influenced by Iranian (BOLOGNESI 1960; MEYER fthc.; SCHMITT 1983)
- ▶ first attested in 5th c. (inscription), 9th c. (manuscript)
- ▶ on its history, cf. GARSOÏAN (1997*a,b,c*)



Verbal adjectives in *-eal*

- ▶ all CArm. verbs (except *em* ‘to be’ and a few defective ones) can form a verbal adjective in *-eal*
- ▶ traditionally called past participle
- ▶ formed on aorist stem or verbal root (for complications, cf. MEYER 2014)
- ▶ almost exclusively intransitive, passive when used as adjectives (few exceptions)
- ▶ regularly, but rarely inflected as an o-stem
- ▶ a few frequent forms have been lexicalised
- ▶ Examples:
 - ▶ *sirem* ‘to love’ > *sireal* ‘(be)loved’
 - ▶ *asem* ‘to say’ > *asac’eal* ‘said’
 - ▶ *aṛak’em* ‘to send’ > *aṛak’eal* ‘sent’ > ‘apostle; emissary’

Use case I: adnominal modifier

- (1) *ard dimeac' gal surb=n Grigorios zi k'andesc'ē ew z=ayn*
 PTC rush.3SG.AOR go.INF holy=DET PN COMP destroy.3SG.AOR.SBJV also OBJ=DEM
ews zi takawin isk tgēt mardik xaṛnakut'ean zohēin y=ays
 further COMP more PTC ignorant mankind confusion.GEN.SG sacrifice.3PL.PST to=DEM
bagins mnac'eals
 altar.LOC.PL remain.PTCP.LOC.PL

‘Then St. Grigor set out so that he might destroy this one, too, since ignorant men still sacrificed to Chaos at these remaining altars.’ (Ag. §809)

- (2) *sałmosk' ēin noc'a mrmnĵunk' ergoc' ew ant'erc'uack' surb*
 psalm.NOM.PL be.3PL.PST 3PL.GEN whisper.NOM.PL song.GEN.PL and lesson.NOM.PL holy
groc' katareal uraxut'iwnk'
 scripture.GEN.PL complete.PTCP happiness.NOM.PL

‘Their whispers of songs were psalms, and the lessons in holy scripture their supreme happiness.’ (Eł. p. 125)

Use case I: adnominal modifier

- ▶ in a corpus study of 5th-c. historiographical texts (MEYER 2017), this usage accounts for c. 15% (1042 tokens)
- ▶ only 4 instances of transitively used participles occur, all in one author
- ▶ this distribution suggests an inherently intransitive, passive nature of the historical *-eal* form
- ▶ this is in keeping with comparative data and the historical morphosemantics of this and related forms (MEYER 2014, 2017:39–81)

Use case II: periphrastic perfect

- ▶ the CArm. periphrastic perfect consists of the *-eal* participle and an optional copulative verb
- ▶ in the 5th c., the construction follows tripartite alignment (synthetic tenses: nominative-accusative):
 - ▶ subject: NOM
 - ▶ agent: GEN
 - ▶ direct object: ACC
- ▶ intransitive verbs exhibit subject-agreement in number, person
- ▶ transitive verbs have Ø-agreement, using a fossilised 3sg form
- ▶ resultative meaning (OUZOUNIAN 2001–2; SEMĚNOVA 2016)
- ▶ more on the history of this construction later

Use case II: periphrastic perfect

Intransitive verbs (S=NOM)

- (3) *ew ert'eal i kolmans Arami i k'alak's erkus Asorwoc'*
 CONJ arrive.PTCP to side.ACC.PL PN.GEN.SG in city.ACC.PL two Assyrian.GEN.PL
 '... and he arrived in the region of Aram, in two cities of the Assyrians ...' (Kor. VII.1)
- (4) *ew orpēs etun zroyc'ork' and nma ekeal ēin*
 and as give.3PL.AOR news REL.NOM.PL with 3SG.DAT come.PTCP be.3PL.PST
 'And as those, who came with him, reported ...' (P'B IV.5)
- (5) *ayl duk' or ayžm y=erec'unc' ašxarhac' ekeal=d ēk'*
 but 2PL.NOM REL.NOM now from=three.ABL country.ABL.PL come.PTCP=DET be.2PL.PRS
tanuteark' ew sepuhk'
 magnate.NOM.PL and noble.NOM.PL
 'But you magnates and nobles, who have now come from three countries, ...' (ŁP' (2)§27)

Use case II: periphrastic perfect

Transitive verbs (A=GEN, O=ACC)

- (6) *ew gitem t'ē lueal ē z=xorhurds mer Parskac'*
 and know.1SG.PRS COMP hear.PTCP be.3SG.PRS OBJ=plan.ACC.PL 1PL.POSS Persian.GEN.PL
kapen z=na ew vštac'uc'anen
 bind.3PL.PRS OBJ=3SG.ACC and torment.3PL.PRS
 'I know that [if] the Persians have heard our plans, they [will] imprison and torment him.'
 (ŁP' (3)§66)
- (7) *ew lueal ews ē im [t'ē i Parsiks xōsi]*
 and hear.PTCP further be.3SG.PRS 1SG.GEN [COMP to Persian.ACC.PL say.3SG]
 'And I have also heard that he is talking to the Persians.' (P'B V.4)

Use case II: periphrastic perfect

- ▶ in the same 5th-c. study, this usage accounts for c. 30% (1989 tokens)
- ▶ other, more marginal patterns than those illustrated above, exist
- ▶ the data suggests:
 - ▶ slow decline of tripartite alignment, rise of nominative-accusative pattern
 - ▶ use of copula rising (rare in older, very common in younger texts) → internal development

Use case III: converb

- ▶ ancient Indo-European languages are not commonly known for having a distinct CVB category (depending on definition)
- ▶ notable exception: Vedic Sanskrit (TIKKANEN 1987)
- ▶ the CArm. *-eal* forms fulfils all key criteria, however:
 - ▶ e.g. ‘nonfinite verb form whose main function is to mark adverbial subordination’ (HASPELMATH 1995:3)
 - ▶ type: free/varying-subject converb (may but need not share matrix verb subject; NEDJALKOV cf. 1995:110–11)
 - ▶ semantics: contextual converb (NEDJALKOV 1995:108–9, KÖNIG 1995:59–64)
 - ▶ clause-chaining is also possible and common
- ▶ in the 5th-c. corpus, converbial usage accounts for c. 52% (3827 tokens)

Converb: intransitive

Shared subject

- (8) *isk na hawaneal vaṭvaṭaki barbareal asēr*
PTC 3SG.NOM believe.CVB suddenly speak.CVB say.3SG.PST
‘And being convinced, he suddenly spoke and said ...’ (Ag. §794)

Different subject

- (9) *ew ankeal zawrawork‘=n i sur t‘šnameac‘=n meṛaw k‘aǰ‘=n*
and fall.CVB soldier.NOM.PL=DET into sword enemy.GEN.PL=DET die.3SG.AOR valiant=DET
Mamikonean Vasak
PN PN
‘And as the soldiers engaged the enemies in battle (lit. fell on the swords of the enemies),
the valiant Vasak Mamikonean died.’ (ŁP‘ §69)

Converb: transitive

Shared subject

- (10) *ew amenayn əst asac'eloy patuirani=n arareal handerjeal*
 and *all* according-to say.PTCP.GEN.SG command.GEN.SG=DET *make.CVB prepare.CVB*
kazmeal patrastec'in
decorate.CVB prepare.3PL.AOR

‘And they made, prepared, decorated, and arranged everything according to the command given.’ (Ag. §760)

Different subject

- (11) *z=ors and žamanaks žamanaks iwrov isk anjamb=n*
 OBJ=REL.ACC.PL with time.ACC.PL time.ACC.PL 3POSS.INS.SG PTC self.INS.SG=DET
awrinak c'uc'eal, areal z=omans y=ašakertac'=n [...]
 example.ACC.SG *show.CVB take.CVB* OBJ=INDEF.ACC.PL from=student.GEN.PL=DET
z=arawreak=n xotabut čašakawk'=n včarēin
 OBJ=daily=DET vegetarian subsistence.INS.SG=DET settle.3PL.PST

‘These things he demonstrated from time to time, with himself as an example, taking some of his students ... [they] settled with their daily, vegetarian diet.’ (Kor. XXII.1)

Converbs: issues

Subject/Agent licensing

- ▶ converbs broadly follow the perfective, tripartite alignment pattern

but when occurring with a matrix verb in a synthetic tense, either may determine agent case (NOM or GEN)

- ▶ the same applies to co-ordinated matrix clauses (~ morphologically tripartite)

- (12) *bazum mardik haneal z=jukn ōgtēin i nmanē*
many mankind.NOM.SG pull-out.CVB OBJ=fish.ACC.SG profit.3PL.PST from 3SG.ABL
‘Many men, having caught the fish, profited from it.’ (P‘B V.27)

- (13) *uleworac‘=n tueal patasxani asac‘in*
traveller.GEN.PL=DET give.CVB anser.ACC.SG say.3PL.AOR
‘The travellers gave an answer and said: ...’ (P‘B V.43)

Converbs: issues

Differentiating converbs and perfects without copula

- ▶ in many respects, the converbial and perfective use of the participle are similar
- ▶ the occurrence of the participle as a main verb without copula makes it difficult to differentiate the two usages
- ▶ in the corpus mentioned, the two were differentiated on the basis of co-/subordination:
 - ▶ converbs and their arguments are not separated from the matrix clause verb by sub- or co-ordinating conjunctions
 - ▶ perfects may be so separated
- ▶ How can these parallels between perfect and converb be explained?

Background: perfect

- ▶ the origin of the tripartite perfect is debated (MEILLET 1936; BENVENISTE 1952; STEMPEL 1983; WEITENBERG 1986, etc.)
- ▶ one recent approach ascribes its origin to language contact with Parthian (MEYER 2017)
- ▶ the Parthian split-ergative system was replicated and adapted to Armenian (the system shows sufficient remnants of ergative alignment; for the concept of pattern replication: MATRAS AND SAKEL 2007)
- ▶ key elements of the model, the Parthian past tense: adjectival form of the verb, non-nominative agent, lack of copulative verb in 3SG (elsewhere OBJ-agreement)

- (14) *kw* 'ym, cy=*m* 'c *tw wx'st*, 'w *mn* w'c'h
 COMP DEM REL=1SG.OBL from 2SG request.PTCP to 1SG.OBL say.2SG.SBJV
 'That which I requested from you, may you tell me [it]!' (MKG 1610–11)

In favour of a contact explanation

- ▶ transitive development of the converb and perfect (as found in Parthian), which presents serious explicatory problems for other approaches
- ▶ other replicated syntagmata in Classical Armenian (MEYER 2013, 2017:219–254)
- ▶ similar instances of pattern replications in other languages of the Iranian periphery (MEYER 2019)
- ▶ historical evidence (extended contact, bilingualism, intermarriage, etc.)
- ▶ explanatory maxim: rule out internal developments before belabouring contact explanations (POPLACK AND LEVEY 2010)

Rise of the Converb

- ▶ the similarities between perfect and converb suggest that one arose from the other
- ▶ the diachronic trend of the copula shows that it was rare in the earlier 5th-c. texts (<10%), but a firm standard in later texts (>75%)
- ▶ at the (pre-literary) time of replication, it appears that the initial pattern replicated on the model of Parthian was grammaticalised as follows:
 - ▶ pivot matching: participle
 - ▶ polysemy / polyfunctionality copying: extension of ADJ use of PTCP to verbal function (incl. transitivity)
 - and reanalysis: adnominal → adverbial
 - ▶ adaptation: tripartite alignment, no copula
- ▶ the suggestion that the originally new pattern was restricted to converbial use is based on the incidence of this use and the absence of other finite verbal forms lacking agreement
- ▶ a later, separate process led to the rise of the copula and the eventual ousting of the converb in favour of the perfect

Fall of the Converb

- ▶ while stable in literary Classical Armenian, the converbial use was ousted in Middle Armenian (from 9th c.)
[...] das kilikisch-mittelarmenische Partizip auf -ⁱel ist rein verbaler Natur und erscheint [...] nur mehr einzig und ausschließlich als Bildungsfaktor von Tempora periphrastica in Verbindung mit dem Verbum substantivum (KARST 1901:355)
- ▶ the transition to nominative-accusative alignment and a copulative form is readily explained by system pressure / cross-system harmony (cf. HAIG 2008:193)
- ▶ it is unclear whether the loss of the converb was immediately connected to this process
- ▶ the function of the participle has not changed in Modern Eastern (or indeed Western) Armenian, where it is still only used for the formation of the perfect (DUM-TRAGUT 2009:213–4)

Final thoughts

- ▶ converbs are a transient category in Classical Armenian
 - ▶ likely the result of language contact with Parthian
 - ▶ arising from a grammaticalisation process that, later, would produce a periphrastic perfect
 - ▶ their marginalisation and loss coincides with the obligatorification of the copular perfect
- but it remains unclear whether there is a causal relationship
- ▶ no comparable uses or forms exist in later varieties of the language
-
- ▶ a further, more detailed investigation into potential differences between perfective and converbial use of the *-eal* participle remains a desideratum

Thank you for your attention!

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